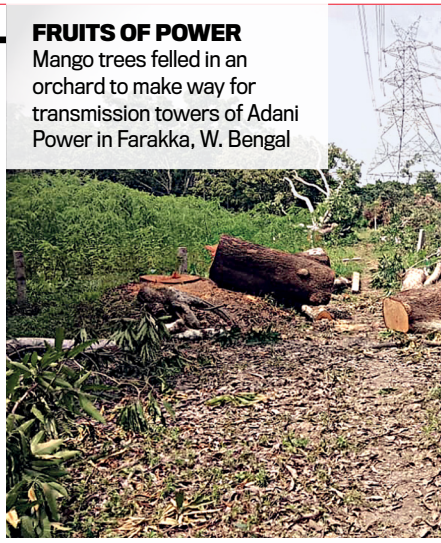
had to be hospitalised; those arrested were charged with possessing arms and vandalising temples. Meanwhile, the stalled work was completed within a week under the district administration's supervision. Five hundred fruit-bearing trees were chopped to make way for the towers. It is feared that 3,000-odd trees might be axed eventually. In all, the livelihood of some 6,000 people across six villages may be affected—small farmers like Dadontola's Jubeir Ali Sheikh, who earns Rs 60,000 to Rs 1.5 lakh a year by selling litchis from his one-bigha plot. Supplying mango and litchi outside Bengal is the main livelihood of local farmers.

Despite all this, the state government, in a recent communique to the Association for People's Democratic Rights (APDR)—which is backing the protesting villagers and filed a PIL in the Calcutta High Court on January 31 against the installation of the high-tension lines—categorically ruled out any knowledge about the project, let alone any agreement with the Adani Group. A state public information officer and a special land acquisition officer, in their January 2023 reply to an RTI [Memo no. 1586/1(1)] filed by APDR in August 2022,



FRUITS OF POWER
Mango trees felled in an orchard to make way for transmission towers of Adani Power in Farakka, W. Bengal

MEGHALAYA POLLS

SANGMA VS SANGMA

By Kaushik Deka



ANI

With the Meghalaya assembly elections slated forFebruary 27, battle lines are drawn between the ruling National People's Party (NPP) and the emerging force, Trinamool Congress (TMC). On the face of it, it's a rehash of the 2018 election, when the two most prominent Sangmas of the state, Chief Minister Conrad and his predecessor Mukul, were locked in fierce political combat. This time too, the two Garo leaders are the prime adversaries, though Mukul Sangma, then a Congress leader, is contesting the poll under Mamata Banerjee-led TMC's banner.

In fact, it has taken the shape of an all-out turf war between the two Sangma families. Apart from Conrad, his brother James, a minister in his cabinet, is also contesting the polls. Sister Agatha remains the Lok Sabha MP from Tura. Conrad's uncle Thomas Sangma, his brother-in-law Sanjay Sangma, cousin Ian Botham Sangma, and Agatha's brother-in-law Chireng Peter Marak, are also contesting as NPP candidates. From Mukul's family, his wife Dikkanchi Shira, daughter Miani Shira, brother Zenith Sangma and Zenith's wife Sadhiyarani Sangma are incumbent MLAs who are in the fray again.

What distinguishes the battle this time is that both chief ministerial aspirants face a challenge not just from each other but from probable allies whom they may need to form the government if there is a hung assembly like last time. The United Democratic Party (UDP), an ally of the Conrad Sangma-led incumbent government, has already spoken about having a Khasi CM. In 2018, the NPP won 19 seats and formed the government with the support of the UDP (8), Hill State People's Democratic Party (HSPDP, 2), People's Democratic Front (PDF, 4) and BJP (2), along with an independent. This time all these parties are contesting independently and some political leaders, particularly from Khasi areas, have raised the issue of the dominance of Garo leaders in state politics.

Process T. Sawkmie, a UDP candidate, categorically said on February 11 that Khasis need a chief minister from their community. He pointed out how development work under two consecutive Garo CMs in the last 13 years shifted mostly to Garo Hills. "The international standard stadium was expected to come up in Shillong, but was taken to Tura. Even the first state university will be set up in Tura," he said.

Meghalaya has three major tribal groups—Khasi, Jaintia and Garo—each resident on eponymous hills. The Khasis are the largest group, accounting for 70 per cent of the population. The Khasi and Jaintia communities have similar linguistic and cultural traits while the Garos are distinct from the two. The Garo Hills have 24 assembly seats, the rest are in the Khasi Hills and Jaintia Hills. Since 1972, when Meghalaya was carved out of Assam, it has had 12 chief ministers; seven were from the Khasi community. But the longest running CMs have been from the Garo tribe, including stalwarts like Williamson A. Sangma and Conrad's father, P.A. Sangma. The last Khasi CM was D.D. Lapang, who made way for his then deputy Mukul in 2010.